

PLAYBOOK

Plays from the work.

Practical notes and working tools on building a business that can keep moving. Written from the store floor, the development schedule, the site walk, and the franchise pipeline.

**THE STRONGEST
PERFORMER BECOMES
THE BIGGEST SINGLE
POINT OF FAILURE.**

Your Best Manager Cannot Be the Whole System

Make the knowledge useful beyond one person.

TAVIS SCHOLZ · 16 SEPTEMBER 2026

You know the store. It runs tight when your best GM is on the floor and gets shaky the moment she's not. Vacation week, a family emergency, or just Saturday afternoon—the second she's out of the business, the numbers wobble, newer hires start underperforming and making calls that don't match what "good" looks like, and you're fielding questions that should never have reached you.

The instinct is to read this as a personnel problem: find another manager like her, pay to keep her, hope nothing happens to her. That's the wrong diagnosis. The real problem is that everything the store runs on lives in one person's head instead of in the store's system. She's not just managing the location, she is the training program, the standards, the judgment calls on staffing gaps and vendor relationships. None of that has a home outside of her. That's not loyalty or talent, that's exposure.

I've seen this play out the same way across different brands and different store sizes: the strongest performer becomes the biggest single point of failure, and nobody notices until the day she's gone. The fix isn't a 40-page operations manual nobody reads. It's capturing the handful of judgment calls that actually separate her store from an average one, the stuff that never made it into training because it felt obvious to her.

Here's the practical move. Don't ask your best manager to write anything down. She won't prioritize it, and even if she tries, she'll write what she thinks she's supposed to say, not what she actually does. Instead, sit with her for 45 minutes and walk through two things: her opening routine, step by step, and one real problem she solved in the last two weeks without calling anyone. Write down the decisions in that conversation where a newer manager would have gotten it

wrong. That list, not a manual, is your starting system. It's usually five to eight items, and it's almost never what corporate training already covers.

THIS WEEK

Book 45 minutes with your best manager. Ask her to talk you through her opening routine and the last problem she solved on her own. Write down every decision point where a less experienced manager would've guessed wrong. That's the first page of a system that survives her.

A Good Site Can Still Be the Wrong Site

Evaluate the market, not just the address.

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The site checks every box. Traffic count is strong, demographics match the target profile, visibility is good, parking works. Everyone signs off. Eighteen months later, it's underperforming and nobody can point to what the checklist missed, because the checklist didn't miss anything. The address was fine. The market wasn't.

Here's what's actually going on. A standard site scorecard evaluates a location in isolation: this corner, this traffic count, this population within three miles. What it doesn't evaluate is the location relative to everything else already competing for the same customer, including your own other stores. I've watched a genuinely strong address underperform because it sat inside the trade area of an existing location that was already capturing most of the demand in that market. The new store didn't grow the pie, it split it.

The other blind spot cuts the opposite direction. Some of the best-performing stores in a portfolio sit on sites that would've scored average on a textbook checklist, because what actually drove their performance wasn't the address, it was something about the market itself: a customer base with higher visit frequency, a competitive set that was weaker than it looked on paper, a market where the brand had disproportionate word-of-mouth. A generic site model won't catch that, because it's not scoring the market, it's scoring the corner.

The practical fix is to stop evaluating a new site against a generic checklist and start evaluating it against your own portfolio's actual pattern. Take your best and worst performing stores and lay out what's genuinely different about the markets around them, not the sites. Population density, yes, but also competitive saturation, drive time patterns, and whether the new location would be feeding off an existing store or capturing net-new demand. That's a market model built from

your own results, and it will tell you things a national site-selection template never will.

THIS WEEK

List your three best and three worst performing stores. Next to each, write down what's actually different about the market, not the address: competitive density, overlap with your own other locations, drive patterns, customer frequency. If you can't answer that for your current portfolio, you don't have a site model yet, you have a checklist, and those are not the same thing.

Financially Qualified Is Not the Same as Franchise-Ready

Capital tells you who can fund it. It doesn't tell you who can run it.

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A candidate clears every number on the sheet. Net worth well above the minimum, liquid capital in hand, financing pre-approved before the first discovery call even wraps. The franchise sales team is thrilled, because financial qualification is the easiest box to check and the fastest way to move a pipeline forward. Eighteen months later, that same location is one of the ones you're quietly worried about, not because the franchisee ran out of money, but because they never should have been running a store day to day in the first place.

Here's what's actually happening. Financial qualification measures one thing: whether someone can fund the investment. It says nothing about whether they can hire and manage hourly labor, hold a team accountable on a bad Saturday, or grind through a rough first year without checking out mentally. I've watched franchise sales teams get excited about a strong balance sheet, only to watch that same franchisee flounder eight months in, not from a cash problem, but because they'd never actually managed a team before. Development teams collapse "qualified" into the capital number because it's the easiest thing to verify with a document. It becomes a proxy for readiness, and proxies get treated as the whole answer, especially when the pipeline is thin and everyone wants to hit a signing number this quarter.

The fix isn't harder math. It's a second screen that runs in parallel with financial qualification, not stacked underneath it where it gets skipped the moment someone shows up well-capitalized. That screen should test for operating fit specifically: hands-on management style versus absentee-investor intent, real experience hiring and managing hourly staff, and how they've actually handled a hard stretch in a previous business or team-management role, not how they say

they'd handle it. Validation calls should ask existing franchisees behavior-based questions too, not "would you do this again," but "walk me through the worst week you've had and what you did about it."

THIS WEEK

Pull your last five to ten approved franchisees. Sort them into two piles, thriving operationally and struggling operationally, regardless of how their P&L looks. For each one, look back at what you actually knew about their operating background at the time you approved them. If the split doesn't line up with anything you screened for, that's the gap in your qualification process, and it's costing you more than a bad site ever would.

Opening Critical Dates Checklist

The dates and handoffs that should never surprise the team.

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The final inspection for the occupancy permit gets pushed two and a half weeks out. Nobody dropped the ball on purpose. The fire marshal came through on the first pass, found a handful of corrective items before he'd sign off (a couple of exit signs, a sprinkler head clearance issue, an alarm zone that didn't test clean) and had to schedule a return visit. That part is routine. What isn't routine is that four days passed before anyone outside construction knew about it, because nobody was treating a held inspection as urgent information that had to move immediately.

That's not really a fire marshal problem, and it's not really a construction problem either. It's a communication gap wearing a scheduling problem's clothes. A failed or held-up inspection is information, and information sitting in one person's inbox for four days is functionally the same as no information at all. Real estate and ops were still planning around the original inspection date because nobody told them it had slipped, so by the time they adjusted staffing, training, and the marketing spend, they were reacting instead of managing.

The fix is still one document, one owner per line, tracked from lease execution through grand opening, plus a rule sitting on top of it: any inspection that doesn't clear clean gets flagged to every downstream owner the same day, not once the punch list is resolved. Not a project plan with 200 tasks nobody looks at again after week one. Just the dates that, if missed, cause real damage: a blown labor plan, a marketing push that launches into an empty store, or a certificate of occupancy that lands later than the lease requires.

A starting template

MILESTONE	OWNER
Lease execution date	Real Estate
Permit submission date	Construction
Utility turn-on request (30+ days out)	Construction
Rough construction milestone (framing/MEP complete)	Construction
Health department pre-inspection walkthrough	Construction, confirmed by Ops
Final health/fire/building inspection scheduled	Construction
Escalation on any failed or held inspection result (same day)	Whoever received the result
POS and back-office systems install date	IT/Ops
Store manager hire date (target: 6-8 weeks pre-open)	Ops/HR
Staff hiring complete	Store Manager
Training start date	Ops
Inventory/first order delivery date	Ops
Soft open date	Ops
Grand opening / marketing launch date	Marketing

The column that actually prevents surprises isn't the date, it's the named owner, and the rule that a held inspection gets reported the same day is what keeps a routine correction from turning into a two-week slip. Build five to seven days of buffer into your target inspection date. Fire marshals get backed up, punch lists happen, and a schedule with no room for either isn't a schedule, it's a hope.

THIS WEEK

Pull your last three store openings. For each one, check whether the final CO or fire inspection cleared on the first pass. If it didn't, find out how many days passed between the failed result and the moment real estate, ops, or marketing found out about it. That gap, not the fire marshal's calendar, is what actually cost you time.

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